By cutting itself off from its earlier elite origins and in mobilizing the masses, the freedom struggle experienced a sea change. Swadeshi (indigenous) production, boycott of foreign goods and the championing of national education were to be the means to achieve national unity and freedom. A significant aspect of the Swadeshi movement was its near all-India reach, finding echoes in many parts of the country. Maharashtra, the Tamil region, coastal Andhra and the Punjab buzzed with unprecedented political activity. Madras Presidency, too—then a straggling administrative region encompassing most of south India and long ridiculed as 'the benighted province' and 'the sleepy hollow'—came to be gripped by Swadeshi fever.[3] This book focuses on one extraordinary moment in this history, when, for a few years, an indigenous shipping venture in the deep south took on the combined might of European business interests and the colonial state.

Originating in the Madras Native Association (1852) and the Madras Mahajana Sabha (1884), the roots of nationalist consciousness were modest in Madras Presidency. Yet Madras was a regular presence in the early Congress by consistently sending delegates to its annual sessions—its third session, in 1887, was held in Madras City. The honour of moving the very first resolution in the inaugural Bombay session of the Indian National Congress (1885)—in which fifteen of the seventy-two delegates came from the Madras Presidency—went to G. Subramania Iyer. (Tamilnadu was blessed, remarked Bharati with pride.) As a founder of two nationalist newspapers, *The Hindu*, in English, and *Swadesamitran*, in Tamil, G. Subramania Iyer was a name to reckon with. With his *Some Economic Aspects of British Rule in India* (1903), he was also a contributor to the theory of economic nationalism that underpinned the Swadeshi movement.[4] As a social reformer he paid a heavy price for championing widow remarriage and conducting his widowed daughter's second marriage. Even though G. Subramania Iyer was unfairly overlooked for the honour of being the Congress president, other Madras notables P. Anandacharlu (1891) and C. Sankaran Nair (1897) adorned the chair. But these early leaders came from a narrow social base, and their activities were limited to writing and